LECTURE 7: PRESENTATION SKILLS

Introduction

Most people are asked to give an oral presentation at some point in their lives. Confidence in giving oral presentations will get you noticed and appreciated. Knowing how to plan an effective oral presentation will give you this confidence.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lecture, you should be able to:

- Explain the purpose of an oral presentation
- Give the qualities of a good oral presenter
- Plan and deliver an effective presentation
- communicate clearly, effectively and confidently with a range of audiences in a range of different contexts

PRESENTATION SKILLS

What do we understand by the term presentation?

A presentation is a means of communication that can be adapted to various speaking situations, such as talking to a group, addressing a meeting or briefing a team.

A presentation can also be used as a broad term that encompasses other speaking engagements' such as making a speech at a wedding, or getting a point across in a video conference.

What is Oral presentation?

Oral presentation is a formal way of speaking with a communicative purpose. It is a way of expressing one's ideas in a structured manner and is commonly used in business or academic situations.

Is oral presentation synonymous to public speaking?

Oral presentation is similar to public speaking, though public speaking could be less structured and lacking in academic content. However, both oral presentation and

public speaking can be treated synonymously because the requisite skills are almost the same.

The main difference lies in the size of the audience; while in the former (oral presentation) it could be smaller formal group, eg presenting a business proposal, or one employee presenting a new concept to the management or giving a report. Very often, this is done through prepared slides run through overhead projector or Power Point presentation.

Whereas in the latter(public speaking), it could be a large, informal gathering of people; for instance, the people who come to listen to their popular leader's speech.

Purposes of Oral Presentation

There are several purposes of an oral presentation:

a) **To inform or teach the audience**-means that you tell someone about something or to give them information about something. To inform means that you want your listeners to comprehend an idea that is new to them. A primary requirement of an informative speech is that it must present new information to the listeners. It can also be entertaining too. For example, class presentation.
b) **To entertain** -this means that you give a performance that people enjoy. If you want to entertain, you have the duty of making the listeners relax and enjoy the occasion. The speech may also make listeners aware of something but that should be secondary. The primary purpose is to entertain. Ways of creating entertainment could be through vivid description, suspenseful narration or humor. People enjoy humor if it is appropriate to the occasion.
c) **To persuade/influence -to** convince or persuade the audience **.** It means to make someone agree to do something by giving them reasons why they should. An effective speech of this type affects the way that someone thinks of behaves or affects the way that someone happens. This can happen in three levels:
    - Changing the direction of an existing attitude
    - Increasing the intensity of an existing attitude
    - Obtaining a behavioural response

d) **To trigger/provoke** -this means to stimulate or to impress the audience. The aim is to insert a particular feeling or memory to people which result them into action or into a state of readiness

Qualities of a Good Speaker

a) **Competence -**The speaker should be the sources of valid information respected in terms of experience, age, leadership qualities, educational background and general command of the subject. As a speaker you have to seem to know what you are talking about. One way of demonstrating competence is to refer to books you have read quoting authoritative sources.
b) **Trustworthiness** -This is the appearance that the speaker gives of being honest, just and objective. The speaker should avoid arguing for his/her beliefs and interests.
c) **Similarity-** Similarity of attitude and other factors between the speaker and the audience increases the audience's linking of the presenter and what he has to offer to the audience.
d) **Attraction** -This is the orientation of the audience towards the speaker. Attraction refer to the relationship of approaching rather than avoiding. An effective speaker will emphasize factor/issues that will cause listeners to like or be attracted to him/her.

PLANNING YOUR PRESENTATION

It can be helpful to plan your presentation in terms of key steps, as follows:

a) **Set your objective**. A simple sentence can be a good means of defining your purpose in giving the presentation, and will begin to determine the content.(Objective is a short statement which tells what you plan to achieve. For example, you may plan that)Try to complete the following sentence: As a result of my presentation, my audience will be able to....
   i. Explain the methods of preventing HIV/AIDS.
   ii. See their role in interdisciplinary learning more clearly,

b) **Decide what the main purpose of your talk is** e.g;--to inform, persuade, motivate or change things. i.e. What do you want your audience to do as a result of your talk?

c) **Understand your audience**: Try and have a basic idea of the size of the audience and who they are. Think about what they will be expecting from the presentation, but be realistic about this. Find out what level of knowledge and experience those attending will have about your topic, so that you know where to aim the material. Is the audience likely to have any preconceptions or misconceptions about the subject that you need to address and put right? How might your audience use what you have to say?

d) **Know your setting**: Find out about the equipment –audiovisual aids etc. that will be available. Check out the location of the presentation; the size of the room (to help you decide on type of seating arrangements), and other facilities.

e) Write down the central theme' of the talk.

f) Write your outline: Ask yourself: What are the main points I need to make to get my message across? What supporting information will I need? Where will I get this? How much time will I need? Structure your talk

g) Develop your visual aids: For example, will you use a flipchart, whiteboard PowerPoint, overhead projector or data projector etc. to clarify important points and aid understanding? NB: Do not use too many slides/points.

h) Prepare your delivery notes, according to the structured outline.

i) Deliver your presentation (see section on delivery).

ESSENTIAL PREPARATION AND PLANNING CHECKLIST

This is a checklist of the essential elements to consider in preparing and planning an oral presentation. Use it yourself by filling in the boxes on the right under "My Ideas".

QUESTIONS TO ASK YOURSELF	EXAMPLES	MY IDEAS

1. What is the aim?	• to buy my product • to adopt my recommendations • to join the club • to give me a job	
2. What is my title?	• The new Mokia 2001 • How to reduce production costs • The INT Chess Club	
1. Who am I speaking to? (Audience analysis)	• What are the benefits to the audience of my product/report/speech? • Are these people the decision makers? • What do they know of the subject? • How does this change my approach? • What sort of questions will they ask me? • What are the answers? • What aspects will they be interested in?	
4. What are the main points I want to make?	point a, point b, point c	
5. What do I want the audience to do after listening to my presentation?	• to buy my product • to accept my findings • to join the club • to give me a job	

STRUCTURING YOUR PRESENTATION

A good oral presentation is well structured; this makes it easier for the listener to follow. The structure should be clear to both you and your audience. Basically there are three parts to a typical presentation:

- the beginning,(introduction)
- the middle(body) and
- the end (conclusion)

In the next sections we are going to look at each part in turn and present the language needed to express both the structure and the content.

THE BEGINNING OR THE INTRODUCTION

The beginning of a presentation is the most important part. It is when you establish a rapport with the audience and when you have its attention.

During the introduction you can do the following:

1. **Get the audience's attention and signal the beginning.**

This is the first step in the introduction: you need to grab your audience's attention and set the scene. There are several ways of getting your audience's attention including: *asking a rhetorical or intriguing question, providing a relevant and interesting fact, giving an outline of the valuable information you hope the audience will gain from the presentation/telling them why they need to know the information, giving a quote or making a dramatic prediction.*

2. **Greet audience.**

It is important to greet the audience by saying something like:

Hello ladies and gentlemen.

Good morning members of the jury.

Good afternoon esteemed guests,

Good evening members of the board Fellow colleagues

Mr. Chairman/Chairwoman Thank you for your kind introduction

3. **Introduce yourself, (name, position, and company)**

Do this not only to give important information so people can identify you but also to establish your authority on the subject and to allow the audience to see your point of view on the subject (you are a student, researcher, responsible for, director of, neophyte, layman).

Eg *Good morning everyone, I'd like to start by introducing myself. My name is...*

I am a student at the Karatina University.

I am a doctoral candidate,

I am X. Y. from 3 Com.

I'm the manager of…
I am a researcher from …
I've been working on the subject now for X years...
I've had wide experience in the field of ...

Good morning, my name is Bruno Spencer. I am a post graduate student at Karatina University in the department of Human Resource management. I would like to talk to you today about some of my findings in a study I did on…

Sometimes, especially when invited to speak, the host introduces the guest, gives the same information as above and then gives the floor to the guest speaker. *Eg the host may say: I am very pleased and proud to introduce …who is…. He/she is known for Now I'll turn the floor over to today's speaker. (to take the floor, to have the floor, to give the floor to someone.)*

4. Give title and introduce subject

What exactly are you going to speak about? Situate the subject in time and place, in relation to the audience and/or its importance. Give a rough idea or a working definition of the subject. Eg *Today I'm going to talk about... The subject of my presentation is... The theme of my talk is... I've been asked to give you an overview of...*

Why are you going to speak about it? *I have chosen to speak about this because... I was asked to speak about X because...*

Have you set any limits on the scope of your talk? What won't you speak about? It may be very useful to eliminate certain areas before you start so as to avoid confusion or deviation from your main task. It also protects you from criticism later for not covering certain aspects or issues.

It is useful to give the listeners some idea of how long you will speak so as to maintain their attention better.

Eg I will not speak about...
I have limited my speech to....
My talk will last about 15 minutes
I will speak for 15 minutes.

You may want to give acknowledgements here too. If you have been sponsored, supported or encouraged by a particular firm, organization, professor, etc. you may want to recognise their contribution. At some point you should ask a question or somehow try to determine the attitude and knowledge of the audience. Eg, Have you ever heard of/seen X? or how many of you have heard or seen X?

5. Give your objectives (purpose, aim, goals)

The main purpose of an informative speech is to have the audience understand and remember a certain amount of information.

You should therefore have two purposes: a general purpose and a specific one.

The general purpose is to inform: to give an overview, to present, to summarize, to outline; to discuss the current situation or to explain how to do something or how something is done.

The specific purpose is what you want the audience to take away with them after listening to you, what you want them to do, what they should remember. My purpose in doing this paper is to give you a solid background on the subject of oral presentation skills so that in the future, at the INT or elsewhere, you can deliver a successful speech in front of a group. What I would like to do today is to explain to illustrate... to give you the essential background information on... to outline... to have a look at... What I want my listeners to get out of my speech is... If there is one thing I'd like to get across to you today it is that… Once you have established your specific objectives you may go on to formulate your content.4 II.1.F Announce your outline. You want to keep the outline simple so 2 or 3 main points are usually enough. Concerning grammar the headings of the outline should be of the same grammatical form.

6. Announce your outline.

Eg *I have broken my speech down/up into X parts.*

I have divided my presentation (up) into Y parts.

In the first part I will give a few basic definitions.

In the next section I will explain...

In part three, I am going to show...

In the last part I would like/want to give a practical example...

7. Questions and comments from the audience.

Let the audience know when and whether they may ask questions. Eg

I'd ask you to save your questions for the end.

There will be plenty of time at the end of my speech for a discussion.

You may interrupt me at any moment to ask questions or make comments.

Please stop me if you don't understand any thing I say but could you keep any specific questions until after I've finished.

THE MIDDLE (The Main Body)

— *Always make a transition between the introduction and the body.*

— You should refer to your outline.

— Select the main points that support your argument but only include as much detail as your audience needs. You also need to be aware that people will not remember too many points.

— Keep the audience's attention; the beginning and the end of a talk are what listeners will remember best. Think of ways you can keep the audience's attention throughout the rest of the speech.

— Explain and build your points using supporting information and evidence.

— Just like when you are driving along a road that you don't know very well, you depend on signs to guide. In other indicate the end of one section and the beginning of the next. Eg *Now that we've seen... let us turn to…*

— Experienced presenters will also clearly pause, change their stance and the pitch of their voice as they move from one part of a presentation to another.

CONCLUSION:

The end of a talk should never come as a surprise to an audience; it needs special consideration.

The end or the conclusion of your talk should include four parts:

1. **a brief reminder of what you tried to show in your speech and how you tried to do so** - i.e briefly summarize your speech in a few lines to make sure the audience has retained the main points. Alternatives are: to state the point of the speech; give the essential message to retain; list the main points and what you want the audience to remember; review informally or indirectly by using a quote, a comparison or example.
2. **a short conclusion,-** give a message that logically comes out of the ideas developed in your speech. This could be a commentary, the lessons learned, some recommendations, or the next steps. You could also make a call to action; the audience should have to do something.
3. **Thank the audience-** give thanks to the audience for being there and for listening
4. **An invitation to ask questions, make comments or open a discussion**- Finally, ask for questions and comments or invite a discussion. If you choose to invite questions, you put yourself in a superior position compared to the audience and should be considered as an expert. You will need to be very prepared intellectually and psychologically to transfer control to the audience and be able to answer any questions.

There are various ways of concluding a presentation including :

i. **Give summary**- This may take the form of a recapitulation of the main points.
   Eg
   I'd like to summarize/sum up At this stage
   I would like to run through/over the main points...
   So, as we have seen today....
   As I have tried to explain this morning....

ii. **Make recommendations or proposals** - eg
   As a result we suggest that…
   In the light of what we have seen today I suggest that...
   My first proposal is...

iii. **signpost the end of your talk** -Above all when you conclude do not do it abruptly or as if surprised to get to the end of your talk. Eg

In conclusion I would like to say that...

My final comments concern...

I would like to finish by reminding everyone that...

DELIVERING YOUR PRESENTATION

There are four main types of delivery:

1) Impromptu: This involves giving a talk with no prior planning, and is often the least preferred method. Sometimes however, we do not have an opportunity to prepare and are called on to speak at short notice. Take a few moments to write some key points down on a card to help give you some structure, and do not panic. Others will be aware that you had only a short time to prepare. Also, keeping the style relaxed and conversational, so that it seems impromptu (even if this is not the case) can be a very effective style.
2) Extemporaneous: This involves cue cards or slides on which you summarise the main points which you then flesh out.
3) Memorised: This approach involves learning and regurgitating a manuscript. This is more difficult when giving longer presentations in that there is a lot of material to be memorised. However, a useful tip is to memorise the first few lines to get you started.
4) Read: This involves speaking from a prepared manuscript. However, while this can feel the safest option, try to use it as a guide as far as possible rather than reading it word for word, as your delivery could otherwise sound stilted. Practice and rehearse in order to remember key points.

Ultimately, choose the method, or combination of methods, that is least stressful for you.

EFFECTIVE DELIVERY TECHNIQUES

During presentation you can use the following delivery techniques to enhance your presentation and make it effective. Lets look at some of these:

1. ***Use appropriate language and avoid jargon***. If the audience do not understand most of what is being talked about, they will become detached.
2. Be suitably paced. Inexperienced speakers have a habit of speaking too quickly. On the other hand, speaking too slowly is a recipe for boredom. Where speed of delivery may be a particular concern, think about placing an accomplice in the audience primed to signal when you get too slow or too quick. the best of these are only aids to assist the speaker.

3. Make use of sub-summaries, signposts and links. Pause at transitional points in the flow of ideas to briefly summarise the material covered. Explaining how this 'chunk' of information links with what comes next helps to signpost the path through the presentation and increases its coherence.

4. Emphasize key points verbally, non-verbally and vocally. Emphasize verbally through listing key points (e.g. 'It is vital that you recognise…'), repeating core elements etc; non-verbally (e.g. Gestures, changes in posture, position); and vocally (e.g. Altering volume, speed of delivery, tone of voice).

5. Be verbally fluent. Effective public speakers do not have to be word perfect. Nevertheless, lots of 'umms' 'ahhhhs' and other fillers such as 'you know' can be highly distracting.

6. Be dynamic. Use punchy rhetoric, vocal variation and non-verbal animation. If you are not enthused, how can you expect to be sufficiently enlivened to enthuse others?

7. Be varied, e.g. intersperse talk with graphs, slides or pieces of video that the audience can look at as a break from listening. If appropriate, encourage some discussion or ask the audience to work on a brief exercise.

8. Include carefully chosen examples – as a bridge between what the listener knows and is familiar with and the new material being introduced.

9. Avoid distractions, e.g. pacing around, playing with a pen or pointer, over use of certain stock phrases. Gain control of body language.

10. Rehearse what is going to be said.

Body language during your presentation

Remember the importance of non-verbal communication!

- Behave enthusiastically,
- make and maintain eye contact,
- smile,
- act 'as if' you are confident and relaxed (even if you do not feel it) and make your introduction without reading from your notes too much.
- ensure that your voice can be heard by the furthest member of the group,
- speak clearly and at a conversational, appropriate speed.
- Varying the tone, pitch, rate and other vocal features can communicate enthusiasm and can create a sense of interest in the listener.
- Pause before key points and stress key parts of the sentence by using change in tone.

void	Encourage
Folded arms	Positive hand movements
Arms acting as a barrier	Eye contact
Steeple fingers	Smiling
Clutching anything tightly	Some movement
Hand holding/wringing	Standing open and grounded
Going on tip toe	Open hands
Fiddling	
Hands in pockets	

The use of visuals during oral presentation

What are visuals?

- Graphs
- charts
- maps
- photos
- drawings
- images
- video/film

What should you put on a visual?

- key words
- technical words
- lists
- examples
- diagrams

Why use visuals?

- to focus the audience's attention
- to illustrate points easier to understand in visual form but difficult in a verbal form (e.g. statistics)
- to reinforce ideas
- to change focus from aural/oral to visual
- to involve and motivate the audience
- to involve all the senses
- to help the speaker

The Speaker's Voice:

The aspects of voice you should work to control are volume, pitch, rate, pauses, vocal variety, pronunciation, articulation, and dialect.

- **VOLUME**

  At one time, a powerful voice was essential for an orator. Today, electronic amplification allows even a soft-spoken person to be heard in any setting. But in the classroom you will speak without a microphone. When you do, be sure to adjust your voice to the acoustics of the room, the size of the audience, and the level of background noise. If you speak too loudly, your listeners will think you boorish. If you speak too softly, they will not understand you. Remember that your own voice always sounds louder to you than to a listener. Soon after beginning your speech, glance at the people farthest away from you. If they look puzzled, are leaning forward in their seats, or are otherwise straining to hear, you need to talk louder.

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- **PITCH**

  Pitch is the highness or lowness of a speaker's voice. The faster sound waves vibrate, the higher their pitch; the slower they vibrate, the lower their pitch. Changes in pitch are known as inflections. In ordinary conversation, we instinctively use inflections to convey meaning and emotion. People who do not are said to speak in a monotone.

- Although few people speak in an absolute monotone, with no variation whatever in pitch, many fall into repetitious pitch patterns that are just as hypnotic. You can guard against this by recording your speeches as you

practice them. If all your sentences end on the same inflection—either upward or downward—work on varying your pitch patterns to fit the meaning of your words.

- **RATE**

  Rate refers to the speed at which a person talks. The best rate of speech depends on several things—the vocal attributes of the speaker, the mood she or he is trying to create, the composition of the audience, and the nature of the occasion. Two obvious faults to avoid are speaking so slowly that your listeners become bored or so quickly that they lose track of your ideas. Novice speakers are particularly prone to racing through their speeches at a frantic rate. Fortunately, this is usually an easy habit to break, as is the less common one of crawling through one's speech at a snail's pace.
  The key in both cases is becoming aware of the problem and concentrating on solving it.
  Use a recording device to check how fast you speak. Pay special attention to rate when practicing your speech. Finally, be sure to include reminders about delivery on your speaking outline so you won't forget to make the adjustments when you give your speech in class.

- **PAUSES**

  Learning how and when to pause is a major challenge for most beginning speakers. Even a moment of silence can seem like an eternity. As you gain more poise and confidence, however, you will discover how useful the pause can be. It can signal the end of a thought unit, give an idea time to sink in, and lend dramatic impact to a statement. "The right word may be effective," said Mark Twain, "but no word was ever as effective as a rightly timed pause." Developing a keen sense of timing is partly a matter of common sense, partly a matter of experience. You will not always get your pauses just right at first, but keep trying. Listen to accomplished speakers to see how they use pauses to modulate the rate and rhythm of their messages. Work on pauses when you practice your speeches.
  Make sure you pause at the end of thought units and not in the middle. Otherwise, you may distract listeners from your ideas. Most important, do not fill the silence with "uh," "er," or "um." These *vocalized pauses* can create negative perceptions about a speaker's intelligence and often make a speaker appear deceptive.

- **VOCAL VARIETY**

  Just as variety is the spice of life, so is vocal variety the spice of public speaking. A flat, listless, unchanging voice is as deadly to speechmaking as a flat, listless,

unchanging routine is to daily life. When giving a speech, you should strive for vocal variety—changes in rate, pitch, and volume that will give your voice interest and expressiveness. Your sense of conviction and your desire to communicate will give your voice the same spark it has in spontaneous conversation.

- **PRONUNCIATION**

  We all mispronounce words now and again. Every word leads a triple life: it is read, written, and spoken. Most people recognize and understand many more words in reading than they use in ordinary writing, and about three times as many as occur in spontaneous speech. This is why we occasionally stumble when speaking words that are part of our reading or writing vocabularies. In other cases, we may mispronounce the most commonplace words out of habit. The problem is that we usually don't *know* when we are mispronouncing a word. If we are lucky, we learn the right pronunciation by hearing someone else say the word properly or by having someone gently correct us in private. If we are unlucky, we mispronounce the word in front of a roomful of people, who may raise their eyebrows, groan, or laugh.
  All of this argues for practicing your speech in front of as many trusted friends and relatives as you can corner. If you have any doubts about the proper pronunciation of certain words, be sure to check a dictionary.

- **ARTICULATION**

  Articulation and pronunciation are not identical. Sloppy articulation is the failure to form particular speech sounds crisply and distinctly. It is one of several causes of mispronunciation, but you can articulate a word sharply and still mispronounce it.

- **DIALECT**

  Most languages have dialects, each with a distinctive accent, grammar, and vocabulary. Dialects are usually based on regional or ethnic speech patterns. Linguists have concluded that no dialect is inherently better or worse than another. Dialects are not linguistic badges of superiority or inferiority. They are usually shaped by our regional or ethnic background, and every dialect is "right" for the community of people who use it.
  When is a given dialect appropriate in public speaking? The answer depends above all on the composition of your audience. Heavy use of any dialect—regional or ethnic—can be troublesome when the audience does not share that dialect. In such a situation, the dialect may cause listeners to make negative judgments about the speaker's personality, intelligence, and competence.

Summary

Presentation skills make it possible for you to deliver effective and engaging presentation to a variety of audiences. You need to carefully prepare right from the choice of the topic, knowing and analyzing your audience, choosing the form of presentation and organizing your presentation.

Speech delivery is a matter of nonverbal communication. It is based on how you use your voice and body to convey the message expressed by your words. Rather than calling attention to itself, effective delivery conveys the speaker's ideas clearly, engagingly, and without distracting the audience.

There are four basic methods of delivering a speech: reading verbatim from a manuscript, reciting a memorized text, speaking impromptu and speaking extemporaneously. When speaking extemporaneously, you will have a brief set of notes or a speaking outline and will choose the exact wording of your speech at the moment of delivery.

To use your voice effectively you should work on controlling your volume, pitch, rate, pauses, vocal variety, pronunciation, articulation, and dialect. Volume is the relative loudness of your voice, and pitch is the relative highness or lowness. Rate refers to the speed at which you talk. Pauses, when carefully timed, can add punch to your speech, but you should avoid vocalized pauses ("er," "um," and the like). Vocal variety refers to changes in volume, pitch, rate, and pauses, and is crucial to making your voice lively and animated. You also need correct pronunciation and distinct articulation. Avoid heavy use of dialect in situations where the audience does not share the dialect or will find it inappropriate.